

Negotiations heat up on auto files

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By TOMMASO LECCA with JORDYN DAHL and MARTINA SAPIO Decoded by POLITICO Launche

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Decoded by POLITICO Launches Today

The future of the world is being dictated in real time by the intersection of tech titans and governments. But there's just way too much tech news to monitor.

That's where Decoded by POLITICO comes in.

We're not here to add another stream to the feed. We're here to help you find the signal.

Decoded and its accompanying daily podcast debut today with an exclusive interview with OpenAI CEO Sam Altman, who told our Brendan Bordelon he believes "the world should accept some bad things happening" for the benefits of AI. Altman also delved into President Donald Trump's new AI accord with top tech firms and his attempted "super intelligence" rebrand, the rash of autonomous hacking incidents carried out by OpenAI models and whether the company should face legal liability, Altman's thoughts on the AI industry money swamping U.S. politics, and his views on key political power players including French President Emmanuel Macron and California Gov. Gavin Newsom.

Decoded cuts through the churn to focus on the people, policy fights and political battles reshaping tech— and, increasingly, the world around it. Anchored by Brendan, Calder McHugh, Christine Mui and Sam Sutton, and drawing on the reporting of nearly 50 POLITICO journalists across the world, Decoded tells you what happened, why it matters, who is gaining — and losing — influence, and what comes next — without making you slog through everything that happened along the way.

Because the challenge isn't finding information. It's knowing what's actually changing in tech politics and policy — and where power is moving — so you can act before the shift becomes obvious.

We hope you'll sign up , subscribe to the pod , and share your feedback .

— Christopher Cadelago, executive editor for Global Technology and California

SNEAK PEEK

— Pressure is rising to reach a deal on the automotive files. We look at the state of play and what is coming next.

— European ports are pressing Brussels for clearer rules as the European Parliament starts putting dates on the next phase of the EU Ports Strategy.

— Last week's FlyDubai incident is raising fresh questions about cockpit security, just months after EASA revised its guidance on minimum cockpit occupancy.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

CAR FILE NEGOTIATIONS HEAT UP: Negotiations are in full swing on car sector files. Here's where they stand and what's coming up this week.

Friendly reminder: The European Commission's December 2025 Automotive Package included a host of proposed regulations. The executive proposed watering down car emissions standards from 100% by 2035 to 90% from 2021 levels with offsets like investments in green steel and alternative fuels. Another proposal sets binding targets for member states to electrify their corporate fleets. Then there's the omnibus that once promised to scale back regulation but has turned into a political battle over the wonkiest of topics: the utility factor.

The question mark: The biggest political fight is over the fate of the 2035 de facto combustion engine ban. The member states have hit an impasse, two diplomats told POLITICO, with a group led by Germany that includes Italy and the Czech Republic wanting to further weaken emission targets. They are opposed by a coalition wanting to encourage electrification led by France that includes Sweden and the Netherlands. The next discussion in Council will take place on Oct. 28.

France and Germany look for a deal: A deal between Berlin and Paris is key to unlocking the negotiations. France wants stronger Made in Europe requirements under the Industrial Accelerator Act, while Germany wants weaker CO2 standards. But as we've reported, those negotiations are also stalled .

EPP rallies the troops: The European People's Party is hosting Mercedes CEO Ola Källenius, who is also the current president of car lobby ACEA, for a discussion with EPP chief Manfred Weber in Strasbourg on Wednesday. Weber is also meeting with CLEPA President and Schaeffler CEO Matthias Zink.

Dead on arrival: While discussions continue on the CO2 file, the Commission's proposal for electrifying corporate fleets was dead on arrival at the Council. A group of member states led by Poland rejected the mandatory targets. Germany is also opposed, which created a blocking minority . The European Parliament, meanwhile, has crafted compromise amendments (scooped by POLITICO) that would set even higher targets for countries. Council will next discuss the file at a Tuesday working party meeting.

Omnibus flatlines: The omnibus looks to promote a compact EV measuring 4.2 meters in length. But the utility factor, a regulatory formula used to estimate the percentage of distance a plug-in hybrid electric vehicle travels on battery power versus its internal combustion engine, is now part of the discussions. So too is what defines a small vehicle, two people with knowledge of the discussions told POLITICO.

Timing: The three files are scheduled to go before plenary on Nov. 23 for a vote.

CARS

HOT WEEK FOR IAA: Deputy ambassadors meet Wednesday to discuss which countries will qualify as Made in Europe under the Industrial Accelerator Act. "Further work is required to achieve consensus on how Union origin should be designed and implemented," reads a steering note prepared by the Irish Council presidency and obtained by our colleague Jasper Bennink.

Pick one: EU country representatives will discuss three options for inclusion in the Made in Europe club: EU-27 only; extension to free trade and public procurement agreement partners on the basis of equivalent commitments and reciprocity; and extension to any trade or public procurement partner regardless of reciprocity.

Public procurement: Diplomats will also discuss ways to determine union origin, particularly to avoid circumvention of the rules. Some member states suggest using the criteria spelt out in the Public Procurement Act as a possible way forward.

Last, but not least: The discussion will also tackle whether the same origin rules should apply in all public procurement or public support schemes, or whether different geographic scopes should be used depending on the type of scheme.

PORTS

PORTS WANT THE EU STRATEGY TO GET REAL: Ports are pressing Brussels for clearer rules, funding and responsibilities as Parliament starts putting dates on the next phase of the EU Ports Strategy. A draft report is due in December and a committee vote is penciled in for April.

Parliament's clock: An internal European Parliament document seen by Martina shows the MEP leading on the file is due to present his draft report on the Ports Strategy to the TRAN Committee in January, with a committee vote planned for April and plenary approval in May.

Who does what: One of the biggest open questions is military mobility. European Sea Ports Organisation Secretary-General Isabelle Ryckbost told Martina that ports still need clarity over who is responsible for protecting strategic dual-use infrastructure — what falls to national authorities and what ports themselves are expected to do. She stressed that military and civilian activity should run alongside each other as much as possible, so that defense doesn't disrupt normal logistics.

And who pays: Ryckbost said ports face huge investment needs, including projects with significant public value but limited or slow commercial returns. That is where public funding has to step in, she argued, pointing to the Connecting Europe Facility — provided it receives sufficient funding. She also wants revenues from the EU Emissions Trading System to flow toward ports.

Dutch push: The ports of Amsterdam, Rotterdam, Moerdijk, Groningen Seaports and North Sea Port made a similar case in their Full Steam Ahead paper last week, calling for investment certainty, clearer rules around civil-military infrastructure and stronger cross-border coordination on rail, inland waterways, energy networks and other hinterland links.

Start implementing: Ryckbost also wants Brussels to give ports more regulatory stability. Her message is to implement measures already agreed — including the Alternative Fuels Infrastructure Regulation and the latest foreign-investment screening rules — before reopening them again. Ports, she said, need an "enabling framework instead of a straitjacket," particularly as different European ports have very different industrial and logistical roles.

RAIL

RAIL BALTICA STRESSES: A small EU funding clawback is landing at a bad moment for Rail Baltica, as cost overruns, delays and tighter national budgets deepen fatigue around the project.

Background: Estonia's climate ministry sent Rail Baltic Estonia a €310,814 repayment demand on Sept. 28, local media reported . The money related to staff costs from 2024 claimed under an EU transport grant. CINEA — the EU agency that manages much of the bloc's transport funding — later decided the performance bonuses included in those costs weren't eligible for EU support.

Awkward timing: Estonia is already slowing Rail Baltica spending to ease pressure on the state budget, with €445 million allocated for 2027.

Latvia turning the screws: Riga has also set a €20 million-per-kilometer cap for its section, after costs climbed to around €28 million to €32 million per kilometer. Prime Minister Andris Kulbergs told local media that Latvia had been "simply taken for a ride." The three Baltic states are now working toward a stripped-back first phase by 2034, and say they'll need around €10 billion in EU funding in the next budget cycle to make it happen.

The wider picture: The clawback itself is financially trivial for a project of Rail Baltica's scale. But politically, it's reinforcing concerns about cost overruns, slipping timelines and capitals running out of patience.

AVIATION

FLYDUBAI INCIDENT RAISES QUESTIONS ABOUT COCKPIT SECURITY: Aviation experts are looking at the implications of Wednesday's emergency landing in Saudi Arabia of a Flydubai flight bound for Tel Aviv. The co-pilot reportedly assaulted the captain and the aircraft entered a steep descent , which raises fresh questions about cockpit security.

The precedent: The 2015 Germanwings crash in the French Alps — deliberately caused by the co-pilot — prompted European authorities to tighten safeguards. The EU Aviation Safety Agency initially recommended that at least two authorized crew members remain in the cockpit at all times, but later replaced that blanket recommendation with a more flexible, risk-based approach. In May, EASA reinstated the presence of two people in the cockpit as the preference.

But cockpit occupancy rules are "a recommendation, not a universal mandatory rule," said Eliran Almog, CEO of Cyviation, an Israel-based aviation cybersecurity company. "Europe also introduced requirements for psychological assessment and pilot support programs," Almog told Tommaso, referring to measures adopted following the Germanwings crash.

No guarantee: According to Almog, it is still too early to say whether the Flydubai incident will lead to tighter cockpit rules. "If the reported attack occurred with both pilots present, it illustrates the limit of cockpit occupancy measures. Having two people inside does not guarantee that one cannot attack the other," he said.

Airlines could also take action once investigators establish what happened, Almog said, pointing to potential reviews of "crew screening, reporting mechanisms and training for an attack or incapacitation inside the cockpit." But he also cautioned against technical changes that could introduce new risks.

"Making cockpit access easier can create other security risks, while adding automated intervention can introduce safety risks of its own," he said. "The response should build on the investigation, rather than assume a stronger door or one additional procedure will solve the problem."

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